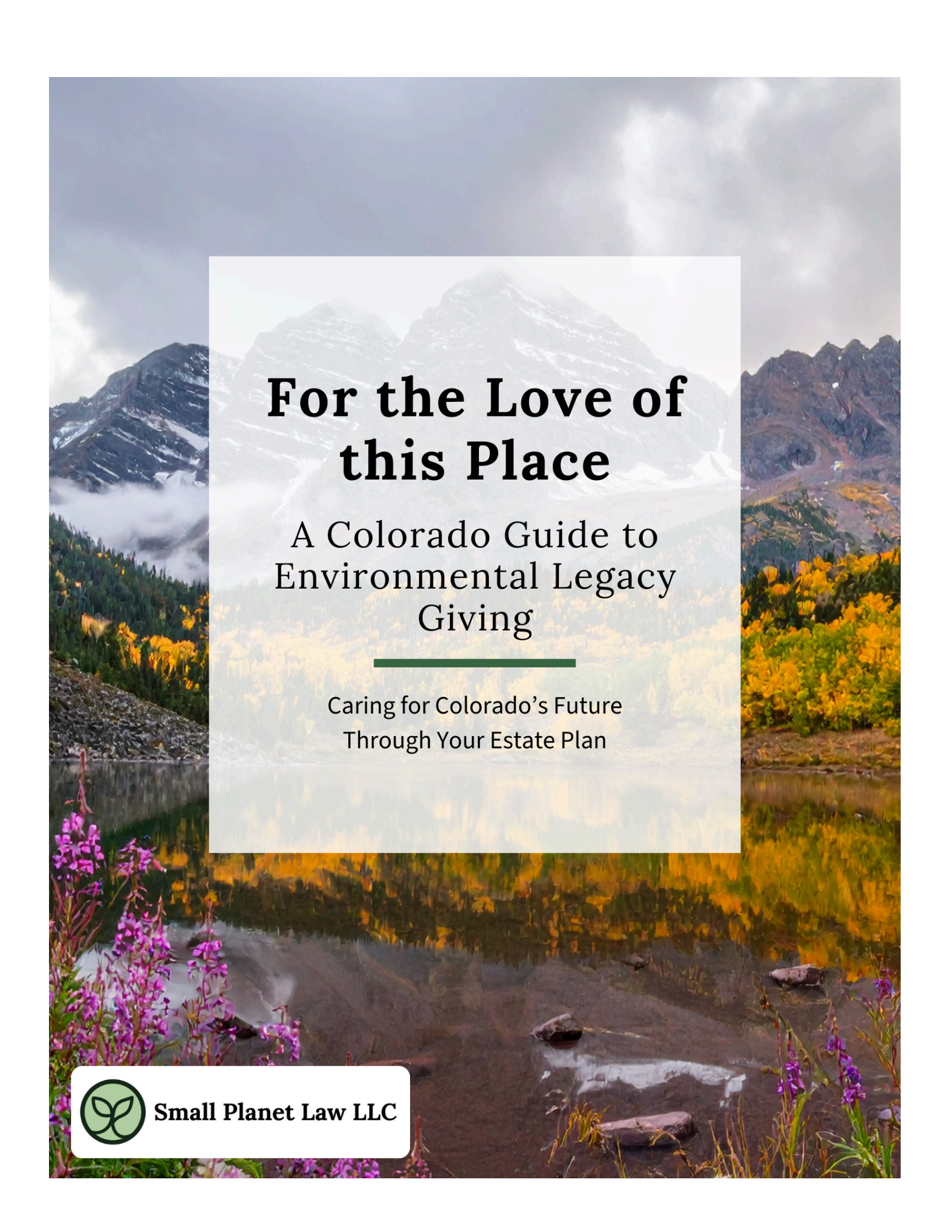




For the Love of this Place

A Colorado Guide to Environmental Legacy Giving

Caring for Colorado's Future
Through Your Estate Plan



Small Planet Law LLC

For the Love of This Place: A Colorado Guide to Environmental Legacy Giving

Caring for Colorado's Future Through Your Estate Plan

Colorado's landscapes shape our lives — the mountains, forests, rivers, and open spaces that hold our memories and ground our sense of home. Planned giving is one way to care for these places and our communities long into the future.

This guide offers a clear framework for how to include environmental giving in your estate plan. It's designed to help you reflect on your values, explore Colorado nonprofits, and understand the charitable tools available to you. You don't need to have everything figured out before you start the estate planning process. This guide simply gives you a strong starting point.

Read on for a grounded, step-by-step approach to planning your own legacy of environmental stewardship:

- ☐ **STEP 1.** [Explore Your Values](#)
- ☐ **STEP 2.** [Identified Aligned Causes and Organizations](#)
- ☐ **STEP 3.** [Understand Different Tools for Giving](#)
- ☐ **STEP 4.** [Evaluate Your Assets](#)
- ☐ **STEP 5.** [Craft Your Giving Strategy](#)
- ☐ **[BONUS RESOURCES](#)**

How Small Planet Law Supports You

As your estate planning partner, Small Planet Law helps you design a plan that reflects your values, supports your loved ones, and contributes to the long-term wellbeing of our one precious small planet. This guide gives you a head start so that our work together is focused, intentional, and aligned with what matters most to you.

STEP 1. Explore Your Values

Your values are the foundation of your legacy. Before choosing nonprofits or particular giving strategies, it's helpful to reflect on the places, experiences, and commitments that shape your relationship with Colorado's natural world.

This section helps you articulate the “why” behind your giving — which will guide the “how.”

What Environmental Stewardship Means in Colorado

Coloradans often hold a deep sense of reciprocity with the land and our communities. Stewardship here can look like:

- Protecting wildlife corridors and migration routes
- Supporting climate resilience in fire-prone communities
- Preserving working lands and open spaces
- Restoring watersheds and river systems
- Strengthening community-based environmental justice efforts

Your legacy can support any combination of these priorities. Take a few minutes to journal, draw, or record an audio note about what matters most to you. Here are some questions to get your wheels turning...

The Places That Shaped You • What Colorado landscapes, ecosystems, or communities have been meaningful in your life? • Are there places you hope future generations will experience as you have?	Environmental Commitments Which of these commitments (or others) resonate most with you? • Conservation of land and open spaces • Climate action and renewable energy • Wildlife and animal protection • Land stewardship and working lands • Community resilience and environmental justice
Your Hopes for the Future • What kind of Colorado do you hope your children, grandchildren, or community will inherit? • What environmental challenges feel most urgent to you?	Your Legacy Intentions • What impact do you hope your giving will have? • What values do you want your estate plan to reflect?

STEP 2. Identified Aligned Causes and Organizations

Colorado is home to many exceptional environmental organizations. To keep this guide focused and approachable, the list below highlights a small number of high-quality nonprofits in each category. These are not endorsements — simply examples to help you explore what resonates with you.

Each organization is briefly described so you can get a sense of its mission and approach. Below the list is a Nonprofit Research Checklist you can use to explore other nonprofits that may align with your values. Spend some time listing and researching the environmental causes and organizations you want to support in your legacy.

Colorado Causes and Supporting Nonprofits

Conservation Colorado Open Lands Protects Colorado’s working lands, wildlife habitat, and open spaces through conservation easements and long-term stewardship partnerships. Colorado Cattlemen’s Agricultural Land Trust Works with ranching families to conserve agricultural lands, protect wildlife habitat, and support rural communities. The Nature Conservancy – Colorado Focuses on large-scale conservation projects, forest health, water protection, and climate resilience across the state.	Climate Action 350 Colorado A grassroots climate organization focused on reducing emissions, advancing renewable energy, and supporting climate justice. Collective Clean Energy Fund (CCEF) Flexible, below-market financing to expand energy-efficiency, electrification, and renewable-energy access—especially for low-income, disadvantaged, and rural communities. Colorado Renewable Energy Society Promotes renewable energy, energy efficiency, and climate-smart policy across Colorado.
Wildlife Protection Rocky Mountain Wild Protects biodiversity through research, advocacy, and habitat conservation, with a focus on threatened and endangered species. Colorado Wildlife Federation Advocates for wildlife habitat, responsible recreation, and science-based conservation policy. Birds of Prey Foundation Provides rehabilitation for injured raptors and supports public education about Colorado’s birds of prey.	Community Resilience Coalition for the Upper South Platte Works to protect the watershed through fire mitigation, forest health, and community-based restoration. Wildfire Adapted Partnership Supports wildfire-prone communities in southwest Colorado with education, mitigation planning, and resilience strategies. San Juan Mountain Association Engages volunteers and communities in stewardship, conservation education, and public lands protection.
Land Stewardship & Working Lands Colorado Land Trust Conserves working lands, wildlife habitat, and open spaces through partnerships with landowners and communities. Western Landowners Alliance	Environmental Justice Conservation Colorado Advances climate action and public-health protections by centering disproportionately impacted communities in environmental policy and advocacy across the state. Groundwork Denver

Supports land stewards in conserving wildlife habitat, sustaining working lands, and strengthening rural communities. High Country Conservation Center Advances sustainability and stewardship in Summit County through climate action, waste reduction, and community education.	Partners with residents in under-resourced neighborhoods to improve air quality, expand green spaces, and build community-led environmental and health solutions. Black and Brown Parents United Foundation Works to eliminate environmental health disparities affecting Black and Brown families in Colorado through education, advocacy, and community-driven environmental justice initiatives.
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Your Nonprofit Research Checklist

Use this checklist to evaluate nonprofits you're considering including in your estate plan.

Mission Alignment

- Does the organization's mission reflect your values?
- Does its work address the issues you care most about?

Transparency & Accountability

- Are financials and impact reports publicly available?
- Does the organization demonstrate responsible governance?

Community & Ecological Impact

- Does the nonprofit work collaboratively with local communities?
- Does it take a long-term, systems-based approach to stewardship?

Longevity & Stability

- Is the organization well-established?
- Does it have a track record of sustained impact?

Personal Connection

- Do you feel a sense of trust, resonance, or inspiration when you learn about their work?
- Are there other personal or family connections to this organization that are meaningful to you?

STEP 3. Understand Different Tools for Giving

Planned giving doesn't require complex financial structures or large estates. Most Coloradans who include charitable gifts in their estate plans do so through simple, flexible tools that fit naturally into their wills, trusts, and beneficiary designations.

This section walks you through each option in plain language, with notes on when each tool might be a good fit for your goals.

1. Bequests in Wills or Trusts

A bequest is the most common and straightforward way to leave a charitable gift. You simply name a nonprofit in your will or trust and specify the type of gift you want to leave.

Types of Bequests:

- **Specific Gift** - A set dollar amount or a specific asset.
 - Example: "I give \$10,000 to Rocky Mountain Wild."
- **Percentage Gift** - A percentage of your estate or trust.
 - Example: "I give 5% of my estate to Colorado Open Lands."
- **Residual Gift** - Whatever remains after other gifts and expenses are paid.
 - Example: "I give the remainder of my estate to 350 Colorado."
- **Contingent Gift** - A gift that only takes effect if certain conditions occur.
 - Example: "If my primary beneficiary does not survive me, I give 10% to the Birds of Prey Foundation."

Why Choose a Bequest?

- Simple to set up
- Flexible — you can change it anytime
- Works well for most estates
- Allows you to support multiple nonprofits

When It's a Good Fit

- You want a straightforward way to support environmental causes
- You want to preserve flexibility during your lifetime
- You're not sure which assets will be available at death

2. Beneficiary Designations

Some types of assets pass outside your will or trust. You can name nonprofits directly on these accounts:

- Retirement accounts (IRAs, 401(k)s, 403(b)s)
- Life insurance policies
- Health savings accounts (HSAs)
- Transfer-on-death (TOD) investment accounts

Why This Matters

Retirement accounts are often the **most tax-efficient** charitable gifts. If left to individuals, these assets are usually taxable. If left to nonprofits, they pass **tax-free**, allowing more of your gift to support the causes you care about.

Why Choose Beneficiary Designations?

- Extremely easy to set up
- Can be changed anytime
- Avoids probate
- Often maximizes the impact of your gift

When It's a Good Fit

- You want a simple, high-impact way to support nonprofits

- You have retirement assets you don't need to leave to family
- You want to balance gifts between loved ones and causes

3. Testamentary Donor-Advised Funds (DAFs)

A donor-advised fund is like a charitable investment account. A **testamentary DAF** is created at your death through your will or trust.

You name:

- The fund sponsor (e.g., a community foundation)
- The causes or nonprofits you want to support
- The person or committee who will advise the fund (optional)

Why Choose a Testamentary DAF?

- Supports multiple nonprofits over time
- Allows your family to stay involved in your legacy
- Provides flexibility if your preferred nonprofits change in the future

When It's a Good Fit

- You want your giving to continue for years or decades
- You want to involve children or future generations in stewardship
- You care about multiple environmental causes

6. Gifts of Real Property

Some nonprofits can accept real estate, including:

- Homes
- Cabins
- Vacant land
- Mineral rights
- Water rights (Colorado-specific considerations apply)

Important Notes

- Not all nonprofits can accept real property
- Some may sell the property; others may conserve it
- Colorado water rights and mineral rights require special planning

When It's a Good Fit

- You own property your family does not need to hold onto
- You want to support land-based conservation
- You want to avoid burdening heirs with property management

7. Conservation Easements

A conservation easement is a legal agreement that permanently limits development of protect land, habitat, or agricultural use. In some cases, a conservation easement can be placed on land through your estate plan, though it requires careful coordination.

Why Choose a Conservation Easement?

- Protects land forever
- Supports wildlife habitat and open space
- May provide tax benefits for your estate

When It's a Good Fit

- You own land you want to protect
- You care deeply about long-term stewardship
- You want to preserve working lands or wildlife habitat

8. Endowments or Legacy Funds

Some nonprofits allow you to create a named fund that supports their mission in perpetuity.

Why Choose an Endowment?

- Creates a long-lasting legacy
- Supports stable, predictable funding for the nonprofit
- Can honor your family or values

When It's a Good Fit

- You want your gift to last for generations
- You have a strong connection to a specific organization

9. Memorial or Tribute Gifts

You can direct your estate to make a gift in honor of:

- A loved one
- A family member
- A mentor
- A place or community that shaped you

Why Choose a Tribute Gift?

- Creates a meaningful story for your family
- Connects your legacy to someone or something important to you

When It's a Good Fit

- You want your giving to reflect personal relationships
- You want to honor someone's connection to Colorado's natural world

10. Advanced Giving Structures

These are more complex charitable tools that can support both family and nonprofits, but they are typically used only in larger or more specialized estates.

What They Are

Advanced giving structures—such as **Charitable Remainder Trusts (CRTs)**, **Charitable Lead Trusts (CLTs)**, and **Family Foundations**—allow you to create long-term charitable giving plans that may also provide financial benefits to loved ones.

Why People Choose Them

- Can support both family and environmental causes
- May offer tax advantages for larger estates
- Allow for long-term or multi-generational charitable giving
- Provide structure for families who want ongoing involvement in philanthropy

When It's a Good Fit

- You have a larger or more complex estate
 - You want to involve your family in long-term charitable decision-making
 - You want to create a structured, ongoing charitable legacy
 - You are working with significant appreciated assets or long-term giving goals
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STEP 4. Evaluate Your Assets

Different types of assets behave differently in an estate plan. Some are more tax-efficient to leave to loved ones, while others create more impact when left to nonprofits. Understanding these differences can help you make thoughtful, strategic decisions.

Assets Often Well-Suited for Charitable Gifts

- **Retirement accounts (Traditional IRAs, 401(k)s)**
Nonprofits receive these tax-free, making them one of the most impactful charitable gifts.
- **Life insurance policies**
A simple way to create a larger charitable gift than you might otherwise be able to give.
- **Investment accounts**
Can be left through your will, trust, or transfer-on-death designation.
- **Real property**
Especially meaningful for land-based conservation or stewardship.

Assets Often Better for Loved Ones

- **Roth IRAs**
Tax-free to heirs, so often better left to family.

- **Personal belongings**

Typically best left to individuals who will appreciate them.

- **Cash or checking accounts**

Flexible for family needs.

These are general guidelines — your specific situation may differ, and we'll walk through that together during the design of your estate plan.

Your goals shape the giving tools that will serve you best. Here are some common goals and the strategies that often support them.

If your goal is simplicity...

- A percentage bequest in your will or trust
- A beneficiary designation on a retirement account

If your goal is long-term impact...

- A testamentary donor-advised fund
- A named endowment or legacy fund
- Advanced giving structures (CRT, CLT, Family Foundation)

If your goal is to protect land or habitat...

- A gift of real property
- A conservation easement

If your goal is to honor someone special...

- A memorial or tribute gift
- A named fund at a nonprofit

Colorado-Specific Considerations: Colorado's landscape, tax structure, and conservation tools create unique opportunities for planned giving.

- Colorado's conservation easement program is one of the most robust in the country
- Many Colorado nonprofits have deep experience with natural resources and land-based gifts
- Wildfire resilience and watershed protection are high-impact giving areas in Colorado
- Colorado's community foundations offer strong donor-advised fund options

Evaluate the Charitable Potential of Your Assets

Take a little time to list out your own assets and make notes on whether each asset might be a good fit for charitable giving, family inheritance, or a combination of both. Consider your assets in these categories:

1. Real Estate (primary residence, cabin, second home, land, other property)
2. Retirement Accounts (traditional and Roth IRAs, 401(k)s, 403(b)s, pensions)

3. Life Insurance
 4. Investment Accounts (brokerage, HSA, etc.)
 5. Cash & Savings (checking, savings, CDs, money market accounts)
 6. Personal Property (vehicles, equipment, collections, etc.)
 7. Other Assets (business interests, mineral rights, water rights, cryptocurrency)
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STEP 5. Craft Your Giving Strategy

Planned giving is most powerful when it's integrated thoughtfully into your overall estate plan. As your estate planning partner, Small Planet Law helps you bring together your values, your assets, and your intentions in a way that feels grounded, clear, and aligned with the future you want to support.

You don't need to have everything figured out before we meet. This guide simply helps you begin the process with clarity and confidence. Check out **Your Next Steps** and the [Bonus Resources](#) below for more inspiration!

Your Next Steps

You've done the reflective work. You've explored your values, considered nonprofits, and begun thinking about how your assets can support the causes you care about. Now it's time to bring everything together and craft your legacy! Here are your next steps:

1. **Review your notes** from working through this guide to identify your top priorities and questions.
2. **Explore the BONUS RESOURCES** below for additional clarity and inspiration.
3. **Bring everything** to your next meeting with Small Planet Law. Don't have one? [Book a call here!](#)
4. **Stay Connected to Your Legacy** over time through regular review and updates of your estate plan.

A Note of Gratitude

Thank you for taking the time to think deeply about your environmental legacy. Planned giving is an act of reciprocity, a way of caring for the land, waters, wildlife, and communities that have cared for you. It's also a gift to your loved ones, offering clarity, intention, and a sense of connection to something larger than any one lifetime.

Your commitment to stewardship matters. And it will continue to matter for generations.

BONUS RESOURCES

1. **Sample Bequest Language** - how you might write a gift into your will or trust
2. **Giving Priorities Ranking Tool** - gain more clarity on what matter most to you
3. **Legacy Letter / Stewardship Statement Outline** - a powerful way to share the values behind your giving

1.BONUS RESOURCE: Sample Bequest Language

Have some fun playing around with drafting preliminary language for your will or trust. You don't need to get the wording perfect — that's what Small Planet Law is here for. These examples simply help you clarify your intentions.

A. Specific Gift

"I give the sum of \$_____ to _____, a nonprofit organization located in _____, to be used for its general purposes."

B. Percentage Gift

"I give _____% of my estate (or trust) to _____, a nonprofit organization located in _____, to be used for its general purposes."

C. Residual Gift

"I give all (or _____%) of the residue of my estate (or trust) to _____, a nonprofit organization located in _____, to be used for its general purposes."

D. Contingent Gift

"If my primary beneficiary does not survive me, I give _____% of my estate (or trust) to _____, a nonprofit organization located in _____, to be used for its general purposes."

E. Gift of Real Property

"I give my property located at _____ to _____, a nonprofit organization located in _____, to be used or disposed of at its discretion."

F. Gift for a Specific Purpose

"I give _____ to _____, a nonprofit organization located in _____, to be used for the following purpose: _____ . If this purpose is no longer feasible, the gift may be used for a similar purpose at the discretion of the organization."

2. BONUS RESOURCE: Giving Priorities Ranking Tool

Use these prompts to identify what matters most to you. You can rank items, circle them, or simply jot notes.

A. Causes That Matter Most - Rank or circle the causes that resonate most with you:

- Conservation of land and open spaces
- Climate action and renewable energy
- Wildlife protection
- Land stewardship and working lands
- Watershed and river restoration
- Community resilience and environmental justice
- Forest health and wildfire mitigation
- Other:

B. Nonprofits You're Considering - List the organizations to which you feel most drawn and why.

C. Type of Impact You Want to Make - What kind of impact feels most aligned with your values?

- Long-term, steady support
- Immediate, high-impact support
- Protecting specific land or habitat
- Supporting community-based resilience
- Funding education or advocacy
- Supporting scientific research
- Other:

D. Who You Want Involved in Your Legacy?

- I want my children involved in future giving decisions
- I want my family to understand the values behind my choices
- I want my legacy to support both loved ones and nonprofits
- I want my giving to continue for multiple generations
- I prefer a simple, one-time gift
- Other wishes?

3. BONUS RESOURCE: Legacy Letter / Stewardship Statement Outline

A legacy letter (sometimes called an ethical will or stewardship statement) is a powerful way to share the values behind your giving. It's not a legal document — it's a personal message to your loved ones and future generations.

Use this outline to draft your own legacy letter to articulate the heart of your environmental legacy.

A. Opening Reflection

"I want to share the values and experiences that shaped my decisions about my estate plan..."

- What places shaped you?
- What experiences deepened your connection to Colorado's natural world?
- What environmental commitments feel most important to you?

B. Why These Causes Matter

"I chose to support the following causes because..."

- What issues feel urgent or meaningful?

- What future do you hope your gift will help create?
- How do these causes reflect your values?

C. Why These Nonprofits

“I chose these organizations because...”

- What resonates about their mission?
- What impact do you hope they will make?
- What connection do you feel to their work?

D. Hopes for Loved Ones

“I want you to know...”

- What do you hope your family understands about your choices?
- What values do you hope they carry forward?
- What message do you want to leave them?

E. Closing

“Thank you for being part of my life and my legacy...”

- A message of gratitude
- A reflection on connection, community, and stewardship
- A final note of encouragement or love